How toxic fandom came for The Traitors

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Marina Hyde
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How toxic fandom came for The Traitors



Draw near, readers, for these are supposedly dark times in the world of formatted entertainment. If you've been watching the Traitors Fallout Discourse develop over the weekend, since James Acaster's Round Table confession on Thursday gave way to Friday's final, then… you may have chalked up a big new entry to the this-is-why-we-can't-have-nice-things files.

Amazing how quickly some marmalade-dropping telly spills over into headlines featuring the anguished inquiry "Has the game been broken?", and then again into deranged suggestions that the show has been "ruined" by this series.

Reading and watching this stuff, two immediate thoughts came to mind.

1. Jesus, I would love to have a format so broken and ruined that it's the biggest show on TV.

2. Oh wow. It's happened. *The Traitors* has become a modern fandom - with all that entails.

Let me expand. Specifically, it entails a small minority of fairly mental proprietorial stans who don't realise that – and I'm so sorry for falling back on rarefied TV technicalese here – IT'S JUST A FUCKING GAMESHOW. An amazing one, yes, but can we keep it in perspective?

No, would seem to be the answer, based on the febrile debates of the past few days. Alas, in the same way some 13-year-old K-pop stans would cheerily threaten to gut their idol like a pig for some perceived piece of disrespect toward the fandom, so we can see there are fans of *The Celebrity Traitors* (established: 2025) who now regard themselves as gatekeepers of the ancient format, and avengers of what they perceive to be infractions of its codes. Infractions by the people who actually make and produce it, to be clear.

Everything is turbo-charged in this era we live in, which is why it's taken so very little time for Traitors to acquire the more irksome elements of an obsessive fandom. All contemporary creative cultural phenomena are vulnerable to this, and it has become simply inescapable with mega success, from K-pop to Marvel to Taylor Swift and beyond. So in a sense, it was always going to happen to something which instantly became the biggest show on British TV. Upwards of 15m – FIFTEEN MILLION - people have now watched last Friday's final.

As I say, it gives me no pleasure to observe that a section of Traitors stans are now exhibiting some of the key elements of toxic modern fandom. To wit:

Gatekeeping: this is the thing where only they understand the show and what producers should have done instead. Can 15m million people be wrong? Apparently yes.

Factionalism: where the vocal minority of fans shout loudest. Because – see above – most people loved it.

Perspective loss: [cf. it's a fucking gameshow]

Betrayal narratives: the producers / contestants have destroyed this thing we love, and which we somehow think we should creatively control because we watch it.

Conspiracism: a number of "theories" are floating around, including the notion that the BBC fixed it so that the prize could be won by the two contestants playing for refugee charities. Can't really even dignify that one with a rebuttal, but hey – it's out there.

Given the intensity of the feelings some people seem to be experiencing, it's remarkable to note that this version of *The Traitors* format was something no viewers had seen till just thirteen months ago. There have been precisely two editions of The Celebrity Traitors. Those two versions have played out in totally different ways and with totally different moods – pleasingly, for those of us who like the game in significant part for what it reveals about people, and understand that it being the same every time is neither interesting, nor desirable, nor possible. I can't remember who it was who once described The Lighthouse Family as "soul music for people who don't like soul music", but the behemoth status of Celeb Traitors means it will always be "television for people who don't like television" for a small but tediously loud section of its audience. But listen, since they're incredibly happy to offer their furious prescriptions for the show, let me offer them one of my own in return: watch it, but do the rest of us a favour and pipe down because its producers have forgotten more about making compelling TV than you will ever know, even if you devote the rest of your life to working it out.

So yeah, season two of a celebrity reality show and this is basically *The Last Jedi* all over again. If you need a recap on that one, *The Last Jedi* was the movie that caused sections of the Star Wars fandom to lose their minds in ways previously incomprehensible even by their own exacting standards. Absolutely zero toys left in the pram by the end of that one. And yet, instead of doing

what they should have done and ignoring it, the Star Wars producers kow-towed furiously to every dumb and unreasonable demand for the next movie in the sequence.

Fortunately, the one thing we know about the many people who make *The Traitors* is that they are not creative cowards. So roll on the civilian version in January - when we will mercifully be spared whatever would be this show's equivalent of the artistically craven, devised-by-committee, and ultimately just utterly abysmal *The Rise of Skywalker*.

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